

Tenses

In Grammar, we use 'Tenses' to define the time of occurring of the action. The tenses in a sentence show the time of an action or state of being as shown by a verb. Actions can take place in Past state, Present state or future state. So there are 3 main types of tenses which are defined as follows:

Present Tense: The actions which are doing presently are classified into 'Present tense'. For example:

- He **is eating** Pasta. (Presently he is doing this act of eating)

Past Tense: The actions which we have already done are classified into 'Past tense'.

- He **ate** Pasta (He has already done the action of eating)

Future Tense: The actions which we are going to do/will do/planning to do are termed as 'Future tense' sentences.

- He **will eat** Pasta (He is going to do the action of eating)

These 3 tenses are split into 4-4 parts, resulting in a total of 12 types of Tenses, which are described as following:

Present Tense

1) Simple Present Tense:

This tense is used when we want to describe an action that is happening at present. But this tense does not indicate when that action is expected to end. Simple present tense is used when:

- If an action has regularity, which means if action happens every day/every time/every week/every month/every year, then we use 'Simple Present tense for such actions.
- To indicate facts that are universally true.
- Habitual action that happened in past, happening in present and will happen in future

Simple Present Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: This train leaves at eight in the morning.	This train does not leave at eight in the morning.	Does this train leave at eight in the morning?
For Plural Subject: These girls go to dancing class every day	These girls do not go to dancing class every day.	Do these girls go to dancing class every day?

Catchwords for Simple Present Tense: usually, often, sometimes, seldom, always, rarely, never, every day, every week, every time, on Mondays, etc

2) Present Continuous Tense:

If an action that is going on at the time of speaking means if an action is in continuation or progression at present then we use Present Continuous Tense. This is also known as present progressive tense

Present continuous tense is used when:

- Some action is happening now while speaking and has a definite end as well.
- When some action or plan is already decided and arranged as well to perform it at some time.

Present Continuous Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: She is doing her homework now	She is not doing her homework now.	Is she doing her homework now?

For Plural Subject: They are doing their homework now.	They are not doing their homework now.	Are they doing their homework now?

Catchwords for Present continuous tense: now, right now, this quarter, etc.

3)Present Perfect Tense:

This tense explains the incident/action that has happened in the past and still, it has relevance.

Present Perfect Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: He has completed his graduation in 2014.	He has not completed his graduation in 2014.	Has he completed his graduation in 2014?
For Plural Subject: They have completed their graduation in 2014.	They have not completed their graduation in 2014.	Have they completed their graduation in 2014?

Catchwords for Present Perfect Tense: just, ever, never, already, yet,

4)Present Perfect Continous Tense :

Present Perfect Continuous Tense is used for a situation that has occurred in the past and which continues until that moment.

Present Perfect Continous Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence

For Singular Subject: Riya has been going to dance class since March.	Riya has not been going to dance class since March.	Has Riya not been going to dance class since March?
For Plural Subject: I have been reading this awesome novel for two months.	I have not been reading this awesome novel for two months.	Have you been reading this awesome novel for two months?

Catchwords for Present Perfect Continuous tense : for, since, lately

Past Tense

5) Simple Past Tense :

To describe an action of the past, we use Simple past tense. In this tense, the verb ends with an '-ed'. Also, some verbs end differently, for example for 'eat', we use 'Ate' in the simple past tense.

Simple Past Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: Raman went for the movie yesterday.	Raman did not go for the movie yesterday.	Did Raman go for the movie yesterday?
For Plural Subject: They went to the movie yesterday.	They did not go to the movie yesterday.	Did they go to the movie yesterday?

Catchwords for Simple Past Tense: yesterday, last week, last month, this morning (when meaning is past), etc.

6) Past Continuous Tense :

Past continuous tense is used in those sentences in which the actions that have already happened in the past and have been completed before the time of mention. These sentences are formed with the help of an auxiliary verb and giving the main verb an 'ing' ending.

Past Continous Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: She was watching TV when he called her	She was not watching TV when he called her.	Was she watching TV when you called her?
For Plural Subject: They were watching the match together.	They were not watching the match together.	Were they watching the match together?

Catchwords for Past Continous Tense: while

7) Past Perfect Tense :

This tense refers to a noncontinuous action that was already completed in the past. Such sentences are formed by using the Simple Past form of the auxiliary verb 'to have', followed by the past participle form of the verb.

Past Perfect Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: He had read this book.	He had not read this book.	Had he read the book?

For Plural Subject: They had done their work.	They had not done their work.	Had they not done their work?
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Catchwords for Past Perfect Tense: already, before. by the time

8) Past Perfect Continuous Tense :

A continuous action that was completed sometime in the past falls under Past Perfect Continuous tense. Such sentences are framed by using the modal, 'had' + 'been' + the present participle of the verb (-ing).

Past Perfect Continuous Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: He had been playing chess all morning.	He had been playing chess all morning.	Had he not been playing chess all morning.
For Plural Subject: They had been surfing the net all night.	They had not been surfing the net all night.	Had they been surfing the net all night?

Catchwords for Past Perfect Continuous Tense: for, since

Future Tense

9) Simple Future Tense :

This tense is used for those sentences which refer to the actions which will occur later, in future. This requires a future tense auxiliary verb even though the verb would be unmarked.

Simple Future Tense		

Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: She will cook tomorrow.	She will not cook tomorrow.	Will she cook tomorrow?
For Plural Subject: All the girls will take part in cooking classes tomorrow.	All the girls will not take part in cooking classes tomorrow.	Will All the girls take part in cooking classes tomorrow?

10)Future Continous Tense:

This tense defines those acts which will be continued at a future point of time. In order to form a future continuous tense sentence, a future auxiliary verb is required followed by the main verb that ends with -ing.

Future Continous Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: He will be going to Shimla next week.	He will not be going to Shimla next week.	Will he be going to Shimla next week?
For Plural Subject: They will be celebrating her birthday on coming Monday.	They will not be celebrating her birthday on coming Monday.	Will they be celebrating her birthday on coming Monday?

11) Future Perfect Tense:

This tense is used to express an action that is predicted to be finished within a certain span of time in the future. Such sentences are formed by 'will' + 'have'

+ 'past participle of the verb'.

Future Perfect Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: She will have gone by the time you reach her home.	She will not have gone by the time you reach her home.	Will she have gone by the time you reach her home?
For Plural Subject: She will have gone by the time you reach her home.	They will not have gone by the time you reach her home.	Will they have gone by the time you reach her home?

Catchwords for Future Perfect Tense: when, by the time

12) Future Perfect Continuous Tense:

This tense form indicates an action that is continuous and, at some point in the future, it will be completed. It is formed using the modal 'will/shall' + 'have' + 'been' + 'the past participle of the verb (-ing)'.

Future Perfect Continuous Tense		
Affirmative Sentence	Negative Sentence	Interrogative Sentence
For Singular Subject: Riya will have been studying English for two hours by the time you arrive here.	Riya will not have been studying English for two hours by the time you arrive here.	Riya will have been studying English for two hours by the time you arrive here.

For Plural Subject: Students will have been playing cricket since morning at this time tomorrow.	Students will not have been playing cricket since morning at this time tomorrow.	Will students have been playing cricket since morning at this time tomorrow?
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Catchwords for Future Perfect Continuous Tense: for, by the time

Important Rules of Tenses:

Below mentioned are some important rules and the most common errors of Tenses in English Grammar:

1) Do not get confused between the use of Present continuous tense and Present perfect continuous Tense. To indicate an action which started in the past has gone on till the present and is still continuing, We use the present perfect continuous tense. Using 'Present continuous tense in such sentences is incorrect. For example:

- Incorrect: It is raining for two days.
- Correct: It **has been raining** for two days.
- Incorrect: The baby is sleeping for three hours now.
- Correct: The baby **has been sleeping** for three hours now.

2) Do not get confused between present perfect tense/the past perfect tense and simple past tense. In a sentence, With adverbs of past time like, 'last week', 'last Monday', 'yesterday', 'last night' etc, always use simple past tense. Using Present perfect tense is incorrect in these sentences. The present perfect tense is to denote an action that continued in present too. The past perfect tense is only used to talk about the earlier of two past actions. For example:

- Incorrect: I have seen him yesterday.
- Incorrect: I had seen him yesterday.
- Correct: I **saw** him yesterday.
- Incorrect: He has returned from Paris last week.
- Incorrect: He had returned from Paris last week.
- Correct: He **returned** from Paris last week.

3) When in a sentence, the verb in the main clause is in the future tense, then the verb in the subordinate clause must be in present tense and not in the future tense.

- Incorrect: I will call you when the dinner will be ready.

- Correct: I will call you when the dinner **is** ready.
- Incorrect: He will help if you will ask him.
- Correct: He will help if you **ask** him.

4) If something has happened some time ago, then always use 'Simple Past tense' to indicate such activity. Often students use past perfect tense in such cases, which is incorrect. For example:

- Incorrect: I **had been** to New York recently.
- Correct: I **went** to New York recently.
- Incorrect: I **had written** to him last week.
- Correct: I **wrote** to him last week.
- Incorrect: We **had gone** to the pictures last night.
- Correct: We **went** to the pictures last night.

5) The sentences which indicate that something started in the past and continued up until another time in the past, always use Past perfect continuous tense. Many students often use past continuous or Simple past in such sentences, which is incorrect to use. For example:

- Incorrect: He said that he was suffering from fever for three days.
- Correct: He said that he **had been suffering** from fever for three days.
- Incorrect: The man complained that his watch was stolen.
- Correct: The man complained that his watch **had been stolen**.
- Incorrect: The doctor concluded that the man died twelve hours ago.
- Correct: The doctor concluded that the man **had died** twelve hours ago.